

NEP-001 — Neutral Evidence Protocol

Status: FROZEN — MIP-001 W0 / W5 Constitutional basis: Articles 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 23

1. Principle

Same process, different permissions, visible provenance, preserved dissent, no automatic legal judgment.

NEP is what allows two adversarial parties to rely on one evidence record. Its guarantee is not that VERIQO is impartial in intent — that would be unverifiable — but that the **process is symmetric and its asymmetries are recorded**.

2. Case constitution

Every neutral case opens with a Case Constitution binding:

Case · Issues · Parties · Roles · Evidence Protocol · Acquisition
Disclosure · Qualification · Confidentiality · Privilege · Challenge
Dissent · Conflict · Legal Boundary · Policy Version · Effective Time
Hash · Signature

Two fields carry disproportionate weight:

- **Policy Version + Effective Time** — these pin the case (Article 7). A later policy change cannot retroactively alter how this case was governed (Article 26).
 - **Hash + Signature** — the constitution is itself evidence. Its terms cannot be quietly renegotiated mid-case.
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3. Issue register (W5.1)

Issue → Claim → Condition → Hypothesis → Evidence
→ Contradiction → Dissent → Qualification

Every qualification traces back to a registered issue. A finding that does not resolve to an issue in the register is out of scope for the case and cannot be smuggled into the fact pack.

4. Party influence (W5.2)

Recorded for every evidence request:

Who requested? · Why? · What scope was proposed? · What source requested?
What source was rejected? · What priority requested? · Was it accepted?
Under what policy?

Party influence never disappears from process evidence (Article 13). Rejected requests are recorded as carefully as accepted ones — the pattern of what a party asked for and did not get is itself probative.

5. Dissent (W5.3)

Severity ladder: INFORMATIONAL → MINOR → MATERIAL → CRITICAL.

Critical dissent covers: integrity, provenance, source identity, acquisition legality, methodology, proof condition, neutrality, privilege, replay.

Material unresolved dissent cannot silently disappear from the final finding. Not "should not" — the fact pack generator carries it, and a fact pack that omits a recorded material dissent fails its own verification.

Dissent is not an error state. A case that ends QUALIFIED_WITH_DISSENT is a *better* artifact than one that reached QUALIFIED by suppressing a reviewer's objection.

6. Conflict registry (W5.4)

Conflicts tracked for: people, reviewers, providers, models, vendors, consultants, customers, affiliates, ownership, employment, contracts, data dependencies, technical dependencies.

Models and data dependencies are on that list deliberately. A reviewer's employment conflict is obvious; a shared upstream data provider between two "independent" sources is the same class of problem, and is easier to miss.

7. Procedural symmetry (Article 12)

Parties are treated under the same policy. Where an exception is required — one party has a protective-order designation the other does not, say — the exception is authorized, recorded, and visible. An unrecorded asymmetry is a violation.

This is checkable: the ledger holds every policy decision with its actor and purpose, so an audit can ask "*were these two parties subject to the same rules?*" and get an answer from data rather than from assurance.

8. The two boundaries NEP will not cross

Article 15 — No outcome-contingent neutrality. VERIQO may not benefit differentially from a dispute's outcome. This is a commercial arrangement, not a software property. pkg/constitution classes it DECLARED and reports it as requiring external attestation — the code surfaces the obligation and cannot discharge it.

Article 16 — No adjudication by platform. VERIQO produces a qualified common evidence state. It does not determine liability. The qualification vocabulary has no PROVEN state precisely so that this boundary is enforced by the type system rather than by editorial restraint.

9. Implementation status

Component	Status
Dissent severity + non-suppression	IMPLEMENTED, ADVERSARIAL_TESTED this round
Procedural symmetry check	IMPLEMENTED (constitution Article 12, RECORDED class)
Conflict registry	DESIGNED — model exists in constitution checks; no standing registry service

Component	Status
Case constitution binding + signature	DESIGNED — policy pinning primitives exist (pkg/authz , ledger); the bound, signed Case Constitution object is not built
Party influence process evidence	DESIGNED — the event taxonomy carries it; no capture path is wired
Article 15 external attestation	DECLARED — cannot be discharged in software